# Root Cause Analysis (5 Whys) Template · Expert version

A root cause analysis template guides you from a problem to its underlying cause using the 5 whys, then to corrective actions with owners, so the problem does not come back.

## How to use this template

1. Write a specific, factual problem statement.
2. Ask 'why?' and record the answer; repeat about five times.
3. Stop when you reach a cause you can act on.
4. Agree corrective actions with owners and dates.
5. Verify that the actions prevented recurrence.

## Tips

• Base each answer on evidence.
• There may be several root causes: branch the analysis.
• Focus on processes, not people.
• For complex problems, use a fishbone diagram.

## Dashboard (sample data)

| Field | Value | Count |
|---|---|---|
| Type | Contain | 0 |
| Type | Correct | 0 |
| Type | Prevent | 2 |
| Owner | Ops lead | 1 |
| Owner | Scrum Master | 1 |
| Status | Not started | 2 |
| Status | In progress | 0 |
| Status | On hold | 0 |
| Status | Blocked | 0 |
| Status | Done | 0 |

## 5 whys · Keep asking why until you reach a cause you can fix

| Step | Question | Answer |
|---|---|---|
| Problem | What happened, where, when and how much? | Release 2.3 was delayed by 9 days |
| Why 1 | Why did it happen? | Testing started late |
| Why 2 | Why? | The test environment was not ready |
| Why 3 | Why? | Environment requests were raised two days before testing |
| Why 4 | Why? | Environment needs are not part of sprint planning |
| Why 5 | Why? | There is no checklist for release prerequisites |
| Root cause | Summarise the root cause | No release prerequisites checklist in planning |

## Corrective actions · Fix the root cause, not just the symptom

| Action | Type | Owner | Due date | How we will verify it worked | Status |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Add environment readiness to sprint planning checklist | Prevent | Scrum Master | 20 Mar 2026 | Next 3 releases start testing on time | Not started |
| Book environments at release planning | Prevent | Ops lead | 27 Mar 2026 | Bookings logged 2 weeks ahead | Not started |
| | | | | | |
| | | | | | |
| | | | | | |
| | | | | | |
| | | | | | |
| | | | | | |